A PRINTABLE PLANNER FOR RENTED ROOMS

The Removable Home Starter Kit

A no-drill move-in planner so you protect the deposit, choose the right upgrades, and know how you will take them down.

Companion to theremovablehome.github.io · Written by Avery Quinn · $11 suggested price

How to use this kit: print it (or fill it in on a tablet) on the day you get the keys, before you unpack. Complete the photo log first. Use the wall audit before you buy adhesive products. Shop from one budget list, not all three. Keep the removal-day pages with your lease paperwork.

1. Move-in photo log

Walk the unit in daylight and again with the overhead lights on. Put every photo in one album. If something is already broken, send that photo to the landlord or manager before you settle in.

- ■ Living area: every wall, ceiling corners, floor in raking light
- ■ Bedroom(s): walls, closets, ceilings, closet doors
- ■ Kitchen: counters, backsplash, inside oven, fridge, drawers, under the sink
- ■ Bathroom: caulk lines, fan, ceiling, around the toilet base, under the sink
- ■ Windows: blinds, screens, locks, sills, any existing film
- ■ Entry, hallway, and any extra storage or balcony
- ■ Appliances: model area, existing chips, drip pans, dishwasher interior
- ■ Floors and baseboards, including scratches near doorways
- ■ Existing holes, adhesive shadows, unmatched paint, leftover hooks
- ■ Keys, fobs, parking passes, and anything you were handed at signing
- ■ Breaker panel location (so you can find it later) and thermostat if relevant
- ■ Anything that looks like an old leak, rust stain, or pest issue

Album name / date completed: _____

Message sent to manager about pre-existing issues? ■ yes ■ none found

2. Wall and surface audit

Do this with your hand as well as your eyes before you buy hooks, film, wallpaper, or peel-and-stick tile.

Room / wall	Surface (paint, tile, brick…)	Smooth or textured?	Fresh paint?	Notes / no-go
Kitchen splash wall	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Kitchen other	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Bath shower wall	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Bath drywall	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Bedroom accent	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Living room	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Entry	_____	■ smooth ■ textured	■ no ■ yes	_____
Doors	■ wood ■ metal ■ other	—	—	_____
Window frames	■ wood ■ vinyl ■ metal	—	—	_____

Quick tests

- ■ Rub a hidden spot of paint with a dry finger. If pigment comes off, skip adhesive products there.
- ■ The unit smells like fresh paint: wait before using hooks, wallpaper, or peel-and-stick tile.
- ■ Tile in the shower is textured or matte: prefer freestanding storage over adhesive caddies.
- ■ Existing wallpaper is already on the wall: do not layer removable wallpaper over it.

3. Window measurements

Measure each window you might cover. Frames are often not square — use the smallest width.

Window	Inside width (top / mid / bottom)	Inside height	Frame depth	Type
Bedroom	_____ / _____ / _____	_____	_____	■ hung ■ slider ■ other
Living	_____ / _____ / _____	_____	_____	■ hung ■ slider ■ other
Kitchen	_____ / _____ / _____	_____	_____	■ hung ■ slider ■ other
Bath	_____ / _____ / _____	_____	_____	■ hung ■ slider ■ other
Other	_____ / _____ / _____	_____	_____	■ hung ■ slider ■ other

Night privacy test: after dark, turn the lights on and stand where a stranger would stand. If you can see in, film or cafe curtains alone may not be enough.

4. Room-by-room no-drill plan

Kitchen — problem I actually have: _____

- ■ Leave walls alone until I have cooked here a few days
- ■ Consider peel-and-stick backsplash only if the wall passed the audit and I have a removal plan
- ■ Use a rolling cart or cabinet organizers instead of drilling rails
- ■ Keep any vinyl tile away from open flame and inside the printed heat rating

Bathroom — surface in the shower: _____

- ■ Adhesive caddy only on smooth glazed tile or glass, after full cure time
- ■ Freestanding over-toilet shelf or a slim cart for overflow
- ■ Tension shower rod / liner if the stall does not already have a working rod

Bedroom — the real problem is ■ privacy ■ light ■ storage ■ other

- ■ Choose a no-drill curtain method that matches the window measurements above
- ■ If I need darkness, plan for edges (sides, top, hem), not only thicker fabric
- ■ Keep the emergency-exit window operable

Living / entry / studio zones

- ■ Entry: freestanding rack or a single hook on cured smooth paint — not eight experimental hooks
- ■ Studio: closet tension rod, under-bed bins, and one cart before any wall project
- ■ Tall shelves stay short or heavily loaded at the bottom if I cannot use a wall anchor

5. Three shopping lists (pick one)

Buy from one list. You can graduate later. First-week energy is how people overbuy.

About $50 — function

- ■ Tension shower rod and liner
- ■ Trash bags, basic cleaner, cloths or paper towels
- ■ Plug-in night light for an unfamiliar hallway
- ■ Two indoor adhesive hooks or a small freestanding rack
- ■ Cafe curtain + tension rod if a sidewalk window is an emergency

About $150 — comfort

- ■ Everything useful from the $50 list that you still lack
- ■ Curtain panels and a rod that actually fits the measured window
- ■ Under-bed bins or a slim rolling cart
- ■ A better sleep setup if the blinds failed the first night

About $400 — it starts to feel like yours

- ■ Everything useful from the $150 list that you still lack
- ■ One larger project: a carefully chosen backsplash OR an accent wall — not both this month
- ■ Bathroom storage matched to the real tile (freestanding if the wall failed the audit)
- ■ A full blackout stack if you need darkness to sleep or work
- ■ A portable AC only if the lease allows it and you have measured the window and the outlet

6. Decision cards

If you want…	Start with…	Stop if…
A prettier kitchen splash wall	Thicker PVC peel-and-stick panels, no real grout	The paint is chalky, fresh, or the range is tight and high-heat
Curtains tonight	Inside-mount tension or twist-and-fit rod	The window is very wide or the fabric is quilted-heavy
Real darkness	Opaque fabric + coverage past the glass + a side/top plan	You would have to block an emergency opening
Bathroom bottles off the floor	Adhesive caddy on smooth tile, or a tension pole	The tile is textured, matte, or the surround flexes
Somewhere for coats	Freestanding rack or jumbo hooks used at half the listed weight	The paint is fresh, flat and chalky, or wallpapered
Privacy from the sidewalk	Cafe curtains and/or static-cling film, then a night test	The film is adhesive rather than cling and you need an easy exit

7. Removal-day checklist

Do this in daylight, not while the elevator is reserved. Work slowly. Heat and a low peel angle protect paint better than speed.

- ■ Photograph the apartment while your upgrades are still up, if you want a personal record
- ■ Unload shelves, take curtains down, and empty hooks before you remove hardware
- ■ Warm adhesive pads and wallpaper corners with a hair dryer on medium
- ■ Pull stretch-release hook tabs slowly down along the wall, not out like a bandage
- ■ Peel wallpaper and backsplash back over themselves at a low angle
- ■ If paint starts to lift, stop, add heat, and slow down — do not pry with a metal scraper on drywall
- ■ Clean residue with a product tested on a hidden spot of the same paint or grout
- ■ Fill only holes you made, with a method you and the lease agree on
- ■ Photograph every surface after it is bare and add those photos to the same album family
- ■ Bag leftover panels, extra hooks, instruction sheets, and receipts
- ■ Do a last walk for rust marks, command-strip shadows, film on glass, and caulk you added
- ■ Leave the unit at least as clean as the day-one album

8. Optional note to a landlord or manager

Use this only if you want written permission for something borderline (a window unit, one pair of real curtain brackets, anchoring a tall shelf). Keep it short.

Hello — I am the tenant at _____. I would like permission to _____ in the _____ . I will reverse it at move-out and patch/fill if needed. Please let me know in writing if that is acceptable. Thank you.

Date sent: _____ Reply received: ■ yes ■ no

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